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CURRENT ISSUES

On the Ontological Status of Autism: the ‘Double Empathy Problem’.

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Abstract

In recent decades there has been much debate over the ontological status of autism and other neurological ‘disorders’, diagnosed by behavioural indicators, and theorised primarily within the field of cognitive neuroscience and psychological paradigms. Such cognitive-behavioural discourses abstain from acknowledging the universal issue of relationality and interaction in the formation of a contested and constantly reconstructed social reality, produced through the agency of its ‘actors’ (Garfinkel, 1967). The nature of these contested interactions will be explored in this current issues piece through the use of the term the ‘double empathy problem’ (Milton 2011a), and how such a rendition produces a critique of autism being defined as a deficit in ‘theory of mind’, re-framing such issues as a question of reciprocity and mutuality. In keeping with other autistic self-advocates, this piece will refer to ‘autistic people’, and ‘those who identify as on the autism spectrum’, rather than ‘people with autism’ (Sinclair, 1993).

Introduction

Socrates: ...Can you point out any compelling rhetorical reason why he should have put his arguments together in the order that he has?

Phaedrus: You do me too much honour if you suppose that I am capable of divining his motives so exactly. (Plato, 1973: 78).

In recent decades there has been much debate over the ontological status of autism and other neurological ‘disorders’, diagnosed by behavioural indicators, and theorised primarily within the field of cognitive neuroscience and psychological paradigms. The triad of dominant theories that include: theory of mind deficit, executive dysfunction, and weak central

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coherence theory, as well as behavioural diagnosis and behavioural psychological intervention paradigms; all position autism as a neurological disorder, a pathological deviance from expected functional stages of development. This approach when applied to the

当前议题

论自闭症的本体论地位：“双重共情问题”。

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摘要

近几十年来，关于自闭症及其他神经系统‘障碍’（通过行为指标诊断，主要在认知神经科学和心理学范式领域内进行理论化）的本体论地位存在诸多争论。此类认知-行为话语体系回避承认关系性与互动在形成一种充满争议且不断重构的社会现实中的普遍性问题，这种现实是由其‘行动者’能动性产生的（加芬克尔，1967）。这些争议性互动的本质将在本篇当前议题文章中，通过使用‘双重共情问题’（Milton 2011a）这一术语进行探讨，并分析此种表述如何对将自闭症定义为‘心智理论’缺陷的观点提出批判，从而将此类问题重新框定为互惠性与相互性的问题。与其他自闭症自我倡导者保持一致，本文将使用‘自闭症人士’和‘认同自己处于自闭症谱系的人’，而非‘患有自闭症的人’（Sinclair，1993）。

引言

苏格拉底：……你能指出任何令人信服的修辞理由，说明他为何要以现有的顺序来组织他的论点吗？

斐德罗：如果你认为我能如此精确地洞察他的动机，那真是对我过誉了。（柏拉图，1973: 78）。

近几十年来，关于自闭症和其他神经系统‘障碍’的本体论地位存在诸多争论，这些障碍通过行为指标诊断，主要在认知神经科学和心理学范式的领域内进行理论化。主导理论的三大支柱包括：心理理论缺陷、执行功能障碍以及弱中央

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连贯性理论，以及 行为诊断和行为心理干预范式； 都将自闭症定位为一种神经障碍，一种偏离预期功能发展阶段的病理性异常。当这种方法应用于

education of those diagnosed becomes a ‘treatment program’ of modifying the ‘autistic person’ as ‘best one can’ to fit in with the mainstream culture of society. Such views are informed by research that champions the use of the randomised controlled trial, yet discounts the subjective experiences of those who identify as being on the autism spectrum themselves as worthy of rigorous academic study. Such cognitive-behavioural discourses abstain from acknowledging the universal issue of relationality and interaction in the formation of a contested and constantly reconstructed social reality, produced through the agency of its ‘actors’. The nature of these contested interactions will be explored in this current issues piece through the use of the term the ‘double empathy problem’ (Milton 2011a), and how such a rendition produces a critique of autism being defined as a deficit in ‘theory of mind’ and social interaction, re-framing such issues as a question of reciprocity and mutuality.

Assumptions of social relationality

The inability to ‘read’ the subtext of a social situation is often deemed to be a major feature of those diagnosed as being on the autism spectrum, yet it is suggested here that social subtext is never fully given as a set of *a priori* circumstances, but is actively constructed by social agents engaged in material and mental production. There is a tendency in the application of positivist methodologies in cognitive psychology and science to incorrectly assume that there is a set of definable social norms and rules that exist for people to follow. This ideology is also supported more explicitly by functionalist sociologists. This is not the philosophy propounded by those of a phenomenological or ethnomethodological persuasion however. The ‘theory of mind’ and ‘empathy’ so lauded in normative psychological models of human interaction, refers to the ability a ‘neuro-typical’ (NT) individual has to assume understandings of the mental states and motives of other people. When such ‘empathy’ is applied toward an ‘autistic person’ however, it is often wildly inaccurate in its measure. Such attempts are often felt as invasive, imposing and threatening by an ‘autistic person’, especially when protestations to the contrary are ignored by the NT doing the ‘empathising’.

The ‘double empathy problem’: A disjuncture in reciprocity between two differently disposed social actors which becomes more marked the wider the disjuncture in dispositional perceptions of the lifeworld - perceived as a breach in the 'natural attitude' of what constitutes 'social reality' for ‘neuro-typical’ people and yet an everyday and often traumatic experience for ‘autistic people’.

被诊断者的教育时，就变成了一项“尽最大可能”改造“孤独症人士”以适应社会主流文化的“治疗方案”。这些观点源于推崇使用随机对照试验的研究，却贬低了那些自认为身处自闭症谱系者的主观体验，认为其不值得进行严谨的学术研究。此类认知行为话语避免承认关系性和互动性这一普遍问题，而社会现实正是在其“行动者”能动性作用下，一个充满争议且不断被重构的产物。本文将通过使用“双重共情问题”（Milton 2011a）这一术语，探讨这些争议性互动的本质，以及这种诠释如何对将自闭症定义为“心智理论”和社会互动缺陷的观点提出批判，从而将这些问题重新框定为互惠性与相互性的问题。

社会关系性的假设

无法‘解读’社交情境的潜台词，常被视为被诊断为自闭症谱系人士的一个主要特征。然而，本文认为，社交潜台词从来不是作为一套先验条件被完全给定的，而是由参与物质与精神生产的社会行动者主动建构的。在认知心理学与科学中应用实证主义方法论时，存在一种倾向，即错误地假设存在一套可定义的、供人们遵循的社会规范与规则。这种意识形态也得到了功能主义社会学家的更明确支持。但这并非现象学或常人方法学取向者所宣扬的哲学。在人类互动的规范性心理学模型中备受推崇的‘心智理论’与‘共情’，指的是一个‘神经典型’（NT）个体所具有的、能够推测他人心理状态与动机的能力。然而，当这种‘共情’被应用于一位‘孤独症人士’时，其衡量结果往往极不准确。此类尝试常被‘孤独症人士’感觉为侵入性、强制性与威胁性的，尤其是当相反的抗议被进行‘共情’的NT忽视时。

T‘双重共情问题’：两个不同倾向的社会行动者之间互惠性的断裂，这种断裂随着双方对生活世界的倾向性感知差异越大而越显著——对于构成‘神经典型’人士的‘社会现实’的‘自然态度’而言，这被视为一种违背，而对于‘自闭症人士’来说，却是一种日常且常常创伤性的体验。

To expand on the above definition, the ‘double empathy problem’ refers to a breach in the ‘natural attitude’ that occurs between people of different dispositional outlooks and personal conceptual understandings when attempts are made to communicate meaning. In a sense it is a 'double problem' as both people experience it, and so it is not a singular problem located in any one person. Rather, it is based in the social interaction between two differently disposed social actors, the disjuncture being more severe for the non-autistic disposition as it is experienced as unusual, while for the ‘autistic person’ it is a common experience (Milton, 2011b). The ‘empathy’ problem being a ‘two-way street’ has been mentioned by both ‘autistic writers’ (Sinclair, 1993) and NT writers alike (Hacking, 2009), yet despite such protestations, the ‘lack of theory of mind’ myth persists.

The stigma of being ‘othered’ and the normalisation agenda

To be defined as abnormal is potentially to be seen as 'pathological' in some way and to be socially stigmatised, shunned, and sanctioned. Then if there is a breakdown in interaction, or indeed a failed attempt to impose upon or align toward expressions of meaning, than a person who sees their interactions as 'normal' and 'correct' can denigrate those who act or are perceived of as ‘different’ (Tajfel and Turner, 1979). If one can apply a label on the ‘other’ locating the problem in them, it also resolves the applier of the label’s ‘natural attitude’ of responsibility in their own perceptions and the breach is healed perceptually, but not for the person who has been 'othered' (Said, 1978).

Internalised oppression and psycho-emotional disablement

The imposition of one’s views upon another and the subsequent internalisation of this view can be seen to be a form of internalised oppression, where the negative connotations of the normative model of pathological difference becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy (Becker, 1963), leading to a self-imposed psycho-emotional disablement (Reeve, 2011). For those who resist such self-identifications and attempts to normalise, however ‘well intentioned’, are experienced as an 'invasion' of the ‘autistic’ ‘lifeworld’ by people wanting to modify one’s behaviour to suit their purposes and not one’s own (Milton and Lm, 2012).

Autism and knowledge production

Although compared to many categorisations of disability, autism has attained a great deal more public attention and that one could say that the label has become a fetishised commodity and even a global industry (Mallet, 2011), yet it is an industry that silences the

为扩展上述定义，‘双重共情问题’指的是当人们试图沟通意义时，发生在具有不同倾向性视角和个人概念理解的人们之间，对‘自然态度’的一种违背。某种意义上，它是一个‘双重问题’，因为双方都体验到它，因此它不是存在于任何单一个人身上的单一问题。相反，它根植于两个不同倾向的社会行动者之间的社会互动中，这种断裂对于非自闭症倾向者而言更为严重，因为它被视为不寻常的体验，而对于‘孤独症人士’来说，这是一种常见体验（Milton, 2011b）。‘共情’问题是一条‘双向道’，这一点既被‘孤独症作者’（Sinclair, 1993）提及，也被NT（神经典型者）作者（Hacking, 2009）提及，然而尽管有这样的抗议，‘缺乏心智理论’的谬论依然持续存在。

被‘他者化’的污名与正常化议程

被定义为异常，就意味着可能在某种程度上被视为‘病理性的’，并遭受社会污名化、排斥和制裁。随后，如果互动中出现破裂，或者试图强加或对齐意义表达的尝试失败，那么一个认为自己互动方式‘正常’且‘正确’的人，就可以贬低那些行为或被感知为‘不同’的人（Tajfel and Turner, 1979）。如果能给‘他者’贴上标签，将问题归咎于他们，这也解决了标签施加者在其自身认知中‘自然态度’的责任问题，裂痕在感知层面得以愈合，但对于已被‘他者化’的人来说并非如此（Said, 1978）。

内化压迫与心理情感残障

将自己的观点强加于他人，以及随后对这种观点的内化，可以被视为一种内化压迫的形式，其中病理性差异的规范性模型的负面含义成为一种自我实现预言（贝克尔, 1963），导致自我施加的心理情感残障（Reeve, 2011）。对于那些抵制此类自我认同和试图进行正常化的人来说，无论其意图多么‘良好’，都被体验为对‘自闭症’‘生活世界’的‘入侵’，这些人想要改变一个人的行为以适应其目的，而非本人的目的（Milton and Lm, 2012）。

自闭症与知识生产

尽管与许多残疾分类相比，自闭症获得了更多的公众关注，可以说这个标签已成为一种拜物教商品，甚至是一个全球性产业（Mallet, 2011），然而，这是一个压制

autistic voice from any participation, other than in the form of a tokenistic gesture. Therefore, far from owning the means of mental production about one’s own culture, the ‘autistic individual’ becomes the 'product' of the industry, the 'thing' that is 'intervened' with. 'Services' are provided for the carer's of ‘autistic people’ with often little attention given to the needs of the ‘autistic person’ as they perceive them to be. Autism is not just an ‘invisible disability’ to many in terms of a behavioural definition, the ‘autistic voice’ is made ‘invisible’ within the current culture of how knowledge produced about ‘autistic people’ often excludes empowered ‘autistic advocates’ from such processes.

Implications for service providers

There is a spectrum in theory and practice more generally regarding service provision for ‘autistic people’, between at one end those adhering to techniques of behavioural modification, so that children are socialised into what are deemed appropriate behaviours of socially functional future roles. At the other extreme of this spectrum is an ethos of interactive mutuality concerned with the empowerment of individuals and communities, and where dominance and imposition of authority is seen as ‘dysfunctional’. Expressions of these extremes could be said to be found more frequently in discourses regarding best educational practice for ‘autistic people’, ranging from the efforts of the Lovaas model of Applied Behavioural Analysis, through to child-focused and democratic educational ideological preferences. These narratives and practices can be said to be embedded within the wider discursive debate that exists between the medical and social models of disability as played out in the field of autism. It is the view of this author that there is an increasing complacency around the idea that lead professionals and practitioners have a good understanding of what 'good autism practice' entails, for me this is an ongoing imperfect process of interaction and should never be seen as a given.

Conclusion

The lack of 'social insight' seen to be manifested in the actions of ‘autistic people’ is both biologically and socially derived, and yet is also historically and culturally situated in discourse. The experience of a lack of realisation or the lack of insight is a very common one in social interactions of many varieties however, and leads to the ‘double empathy problem’ between differently disposed social actors. Such divergences of perception are inevitable to a greater or lesser extent. So it is true that autistic people often lack insight about NT perceptions and culture, yet it is equally the case that NT people lack insight into the minds

自闭症者声音参与任何活动的产业，除非是以象征性的姿态出现。因此，远非掌握关于自身文化的精神生产手段，'自闭症个体'成为了产业's产品', 成为被'干预'的'物件'。为'自闭症人士'的照料者提供的's服务', 往往很少关注'孤独症人士'自身感知的需求。自闭症对许多人而言不仅仅是一种行为定义上的'隐形残疾', 在当前关于'自闭症人士'的知识生产文化中, '自闭症者声音'也被'隐形化', 这些过程常常排除了拥有权力的'自闭症倡导者'。

对服务提供者的启示

在为‘自闭症人士’提供服务方面，理论和实践上普遍存在一个光谱范围，一端是坚持行为矫正技术的人，目的是将儿童社会化，使其行为符合未来社会功能性角色中被认为恰当的行为。这个光谱的另一端则是一种互动互惠的理念，关注个人和社区的赋权，并将权力的支配和权威的强加视为‘功能失调’。可以说，这些极端表现更频繁地出现在关于为‘自闭症人士’提供最佳教育实践的论述中，范围从应用行为分析的洛瓦斯模型的努力，延伸到以儿童为中心和民主的教育意识形态偏好。这些叙事和实践可以说嵌入在更广泛的、存在于残疾的医学模型与社会模型之间的、在自闭症领域展开的辩论性讨论中。本文作者认为，对于主导专业人士和实践者对‘良好自闭症实践’包含什么内容有良好理解这一想法，存在日益增长的盲目自满，对我来说，这是一个持续进行的、不完美的互动过程，永远不应被视为理所当然。

结论

被认为体现在‘自闭症人士’行为中的‘社会洞察力’缺失，既有生物学根源也有社会根源，同时也被历史和文化的论述所定位。然而，在许多不同类型的社会互动中，缺乏觉察或缺乏洞察力的体验其实非常普遍，并导致了不同倾向的社会行动者之间的‘双重共情问题’。这种感知上的分歧或多或少是不可避免的。因此，确实，自闭症人士常常对神经典型人士（NT）的感知和文化缺乏洞察力，但同样，神经典型人士（NT）也对

and culture of ‘autistic people’, or that they may lack social insight in other social situations due to an easily repaired natural attitude, and the aligning tendencies of their peers. One could say that many autistic people have indeed gained a greater level of insight into NT society and mores than vice versa, perhaps due to the need to survive and potentially thrive in a NT culture. Conversely, the NT person has no pertinent personal requirement to understand the mind of the ‘autistic person’ unless closely related socially in some way.

In analysing the interactions that ‘autistic people’ have with the wider population, it is easy to problematise the definition of autism as a ‘social deficit’ located within an individual’s mind. Differences in neurology may well produce differences in sociality, but not a ‘social deficit’ as compared to an idealised normative view of social reality. Such definitions may help to signpost disability support services, but they are no way of defining autism in any kind of holistic sense.

Socrates: But suppose the words used are ‘just’ and ‘good’. Don’t we then go each his own way, and find ourselves in disagreement with ourselves as well as with each other?

Phaedrus: Undoubtedly. (Plato, 1973: 77).

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‘自闭症人士’的内心和文化缺乏洞察力，或者他们可能在其他社会情境中因一种易于修复的‘自然态度’及其同伴的趋同倾向而缺乏社会洞察力。可以说，许多自闭症人士确实对神经典型社会及其习俗获得了比神经典型人士更高的洞察力，这可能是因为在神经典型文化中生存乃至可能蓬勃发展。反之，神经典型人士除非在某种程度上与社会关系密切，否则并无相关的个人需求去理解‘孤独症人士’的内心世界。

在分析‘自闭症人士’与更广泛人群的互动时，很容易将自闭症的定义问题化，将其视为存在于个体心智中的一种‘社交缺陷’。神经系统的差异确实可能导致社交方式的差异，但相较于理想化的规范性社会现实观，这并非一种‘社交缺陷’。此类定义或许有助于标示残疾支持服务，但它们绝非从任何整体意义上定义自闭症的方式。

苏格拉底：但假设所用的词是‘公正’和‘善良’。我们难道不是各自走自己的路，发现自己不仅与他人意见相左，也与自己内心产生分歧吗？

斐德罗：毫无疑问。（柏拉图，1973: 77）。

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